



## Into the wild

At first, the gorillas were shy, but as Dian lived with them and copied their behavior, she won their trust. This process, known as habituation, allowed Dian to watch the gorillas acting naturally. She began to understand how they live in close-knit family groups and spend much of their time eating plants.

## Battle for survival

Life, however, was neither easy nor peaceful. The gorillas were badly affected by human activities, such as farming, and were sometimes hunted by poachers. Dian's research inspired people around the world to care about mountain gorillas. But, as the number of mountain gorillas fell to around 250, Dian became sad and angry.

In her 18 years in the mountains, Dian fought to protect these incredible creatures. She argued with poachers and farmers and conservationists, who wanted to help the gorillas in different ways. Dian died in 1985. Other scientists and conservationists continued the work she had started, and the gorilla population began to grow. Today, there are around 1,000 wild mountain gorillas. It's the only conservation program that has increased numbers of a group of wild apes.

*Dian's incredible life story was made into a Hollywood movie—Gorillas in the Mist. Her photographs and videos helped people to understand gorillas much better.*



*The Karisoke Research Center that Dian founded in Rwanda trains scientists, conservationists, and local communities.*

